Short Paper:

Heublein PM&C Program

Case Study Stakeholder Analysis

Jennifer Lakey

Southern New Hampshire University

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Dr. Jillian Zambon

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Introduction

The implementation of a corporate wide Project Management and Control (PM&C) system at Heublein, as presented in the case study from *Project Management: A Managerial Approach* (Meredith et al., 2021), represents a significant organizational change initiative that affects multiple business units, engineering departments, and corporate leadership. The purpose of this stakeholder analysis is to identify the primary stakeholders involved in the PM&C Program, evaluate their interests and potential areas of conflict, and outline communication strategies that support alignment, reduce resistance, and promote successful implementation. Since the PM&C Program was intentionally designed as a model project, effective stakeholder engagement is essential to achieving the organization's goals of improved project execution, better capital utilization, and stronger cross-group coordination. Clear and consistent communication is a critical component of this engagement, as it establishes shared expectations, reduces uncertainty, and supports coordinated action across diverse stakeholder groups (Northeastern University, 2023).

Stakeholder Interests

The PM&C Program involves a diverse set of stakeholders whose interests reflect their roles, responsibilities, and organizational priorities. Understanding these interests is essential for anticipating concerns, aligning expectations, and designing communication strategies that support successful implementation (Meredith et al., 2021).

Corporate Management

Corporate leadership initiated the PM&C Program in response to cost overruns, inconsistent project execution, and the need for more efficient capital allocation across Heublein's diverse operating Groups. Their primary interest is establishing a system that strengthens financial discipline and ensures that major capital projects remain within approved budgets and schedules. This aligns with the broader organizational goal of improving return on investment and optimizing scarce capital resources.

Corporate leaders also value standardized reporting that provides visibility across Groups. Because each Group previously used different processes and levels of documentation, corporate management seeks a PM&C system that produces consistent, comparable data to support strategic decision making. This interest reflects the importance of reliable information flow in managing complex project portfolios (Northeastern University, 2023).

Additionally, corporate leadership is invested in long term strategic planning. They want a PM&C system that not only improves current project performance but also builds organizational capability for future initiatives. Their interest includes ensuring that the system is scalable, sustainable, and adaptable to new project types such as R&D or new product development, as described in the case.

Corporate Facilities and Manufacturing Planning (F&MP)

F&MP serves as the internal sponsor and oversight body for the PM&C Program. Their interests are shaped by their dual role: providing technical consulting services and reviewing all Capital Appropriation Requests. As a result, they are deeply invested in developing a PM&C system that is technically sound, methodologically rigorous, and aligned with corporate expectations.

A major interest for F&MP is system integrity and consistency. They want a PM&C framework that establishes clear planning standards, improves project definition, and strengthens the quality of capital requests submitted by the Groups. This interest reflects the project management principle that strong front-end planning reduces downstream risk and improves execution outcomes (Meredith et al., 2021).

F&MP is also interested in cross-group communication and coordination. Because they work with all Groups, they value a system that improves information flow, reduces ambiguity, and supports collaborative problem solving. Their interest in training and education reflects their commitment to building organizational capability and ensuring that all Groups can effectively use the PM&C tools.

Finally, F&MP is invested in organizational acceptance. They want a system that Groups perceive as useful rather than burdensome, which is why they supported a consensus-based design process and the use of an external consultant to facilitate discussions.

Group Engineering Managers

Engineering managers across the Spirits, Wines, Food Service, and Franchising Groups have interests shaped by their operational responsibilities and the diversity of their project environments. Their strongest interest is maintaining operational autonomy. Because each Group manages different types of capital projects with varying levels of complexity, engineering managers want a PM&C system that is flexible enough to accommodate their unique needs.

They also value practical tools and procedures that improve project execution without imposing excessive administrative burden. Their interest includes clear planning guidelines, accessible reporting formats, and tools that support scheduling, resource allocation, and cost tracking. Meredith et al. (2021) note that stakeholder interests often diverge when standardization intersects with local operational needs, which is evident in this case.

Another key interest is staff capability and workload balance. Engineering managers want training that equips their teams to use the PM&C system effectively. They also want assurance that new requirements will not overwhelm already stretched engineering resources.

Finally, engineering managers are interested in visibility and communication. They want a system that helps them monitor project progress, identify risks early, and communicate effectively with corporate leadership. This interest reflects the importance of structured communication channels in managing complex engineering projects (Northeastern University, 2023).

Engineering Staff and Project Teams

Engineering staff and project teams are responsible for the day-to-day execution of project planning, scheduling, reporting, and technical work within the PM&C system. Their primary interests center on usability, efficiency, and clarity. Staff members want a system that improves planning accuracy and coordination while remaining practical and manageable within their existing workload. This reflects the broader project management principle that operational stakeholders prioritize tools and processes that support task execution without adding unnecessary administrative burden (Meredith et al., 2021).

Another key interest for engineering staff is access to training and skill development. Because the PM&C Program introduces new practices such as work breakdown structures, network development, and structured reporting, staff members value training that is clear, accessible, and directly applicable to their daily responsibilities. They also want opportunities to build confidence with new tools before they are held accountable for using them.

Engineering teams are also strongly interested in clear accountability structures. The case highlights the use of an accountability matrix to define who initiates, approves, or provides input for each component of the PM&C system. For project teams, this clarity supports efficient coordination, reduces ambiguity, and helps ensure that responsibilities are understood across Groups.

Finally, engineering staff value communication channels that help them understand expectations, raise questions, and stay informed about changes to procedures or reporting requirements. Because they are directly responsible for implementing the PM&C system, they are interested in communication that is consistent, timely, and aligned with their operational needs. This interest reflects the importance of structured communication in supporting project execution and stakeholder alignment (Northeastern University, 2023).

External Consultant

The external consultant plays a central role in designing and facilitating the PM&C Program. Their primary interest is delivering a system that meets Heublein's needs while aligning with established project management best practices. They are invested in ensuring that the system is conceptually sound, practically applicable, and well received by stakeholders across the organization.

The consultant is also interested in effective facilitation and consensus building. The case describes the consultant as a "lightning rod" for criticism, which allows internal stakeholders to express concerns without damaging long-term working relationships. This reflects the consultant's interest in maintaining neutrality and supporting constructive dialogue.

Additionally, the consultant values successful adoption and long-term sustainability of the PM&C system. Their interest includes ensuring that training is effective, documentation is clear, and the system is flexible enough to evolve with organizational needs. This aligns with the broader principle that stakeholder engagement and education are critical to successful project implementation (Meredith et al., 2021).

Areas of Conflict

Given the diversity of stakeholder interests, several areas of tension are likely to emerge during the design and implementation of the PM&C Program. These conflicts arise from differences in priorities, operational needs, authority structures, and expectations about standardization. Understanding these conflict points is essential for anticipating resistance and designing communication strategies that support alignment (Meredith et al., 2021).

Conflicts Within Groups

Within individual Groups, engineering managers and project teams may experience internal conflict related to workload, resource allocation, and the adoption of new planning and reporting practices. Engineering managers are responsible for balancing day-to-day operational demands with the additional effort required to implement the PM&C system. This can create tension when staff perceive the new processes as increasing administrative burden or disrupting established workflows.

Project teams may also experience task conflict, which occurs when individuals disagree about how work should be completed, especially when new tools such as work breakdown structures or network diagrams are introduced (Indeed, 2023). Additionally, process conflict may arise if staff feel uncertain about new procedures or unclear about how responsibilities are divided. These internal tensions reflect the competing interests between maintaining operational efficiency and adopting new project management practices intended to improve long-term performance.

Conflicts Between Groups

Since each Group operates with different project types, staffing levels, and engineering capabilities, disagreements may emerge regarding the level of standardization required across the organization. Groups with mature engineering departments may prefer minimal change, valuing autonomy and established processes. In contrast, Groups with less formalized project management practices may welcome more structured guidance.

These differences create tension around expectations for reporting, training, and planning rigor. For example, Groups managing large capital projects may find detailed planning tools essential, while Groups managing smaller or more routine projects may view them as excessive. This reflects a classic structural divergence, where variations in organizational context lead to differing interpretations of what constitutes an appropriate level of process formality (HelpGuide, 2023).

Differences in project scale also contribute to conflict. Groups with high capital spending may prioritize detailed cost tracking, while Groups with smaller budgets may resist additional reporting requirements. These tensions stem from competing interests between flexibility and consistency, both of which are legitimate but difficult to balance across a diverse organization.

Conflicts Between Groups and Corporate Management

Corporate management's interest in standardized reporting and improved financial control may conflict with Group managers' need for flexibility and autonomy. Groups may perceive corporate expectations as overly rigid or misaligned with their operational realities, especially if they lack the staffing or tools needed to meet new requirements.

This tension reflects a classic hierarchical or structural conflict, where differences in authority and organizational perspective create friction (HelpGuide, 2023). Corporate leaders focus on portfolio-level visibility and capital optimization, while Group managers focus on operational feasibility and resource constraints. When corporate expectations for improved cost control or schedule discipline exceed what Groups believe is realistic, conflict is likely to arise.

Additionally, Groups may feel that corporate oversight threatens their ability to tailor project management practices to their unique environments. This tension is heightened by the fact that the PM&C Program introduces new reporting structures that may be perceived as intrusive or burdensome.

Conflicts Between F&MP and Engineering Departments

F&MP's role as the designer and overseer of the PM&C Program may create tension with Group engineering departments, particularly if Groups feel their input is undervalued or if the system appears too centralized. Although the program was intentionally designed through a consensus-based process, differences in interpretation of project management principles may still lead to disagreements about required procedures, reporting expectations, or the level of detail needed in planning documents.

Engineering departments may also question whether F&MP fully understands the operational realities of their Groups, especially when it comes to staffing limitations or the complexity of specific project types. This can create relationship-based conflict, where stakeholders question the intentions or understanding of another party (Indeed, 2023).

F&MP, on the other hand, may feel tension when Groups resist adopting practices that are necessary for achieving corporate objectives. Their interest in system integrity and consistency may conflict with Group preferences for customization and autonomy. These competing interests create a natural friction point that must be managed through clear communication and collaborative problem solving.

Communication Plan Overview

A structured and intentional communication plan is essential for maintaining alignment, reducing resistance, and supporting coordinated implementation of the PM&C Program across Heublein's diverse organizational landscape. Effective communication ensures that stakeholders understand expectations, receive timely information, and have opportunities to provide input throughout the project lifecycle (Northeastern University, 2023). The communication plan for the PM&C Program incorporates several core components designed to promote transparency, consistency, and shared understanding while supporting the diverse needs of Corporate Management, F&MP, Group Engineering Managers, and project teams.

Regular Status Updates

Regular status updates from the program manager to Corporate Management and Group leadership provide predictable visibility into project progress. These updates summarize milestone achievement, emerging risks, and any changes in scope or timing. This structured reporting cadence supports corporate interests in oversight and financial control while giving Groups clarity about expectations and upcoming requirements. Predictable updates also help maintain alignment across Groups that operate with different project types and resource levels.

Workshops and Training Sessions

Workshops and training sessions build shared understanding of PM&C principles and ensure that stakeholders are prepared to use new tools and processes. These sessions mirror the educational seminars used during the design phase and help establish a common foundation for implementation. Because Groups vary in their project management maturity, training provides a consistent baseline while allowing participants to ask questions, practice new skills, and clarify expectations.

Clear and Accessible Documentation

Documentation such as procedures manuals, reporting templates, WBS guidelines, and network development instructions provides stakeholders with consistent reference materials. Clear documentation supports standardization across Groups while still allowing for tailored application where appropriate. It also reduces ambiguity by ensuring that all stakeholders have access to the same definitions, processes, and expectations, which is essential for coordinated implementation.

Feedback Mechanisms and Two-Way Communication

The communication plan includes structured opportunities for stakeholders to provide input, including milestone reviews, impact statements, and follow-up discussions. These mechanisms ensure that concerns are identified early and that implementation decisions reflect stakeholder perspectives. Two-way communication reinforces stakeholder ownership and supports continuous improvement of the PM&C system.

Cross-Group Communication Channels

Cross-group communication channels, such as inter-Group meetings or shared digital workspaces, support coordination and shared learning across Heublein's diverse operating units. These channels help ensure that Groups remain aligned as the PM&C system is adopted and provide opportunities for sharing best practices, clarifying expectations, and addressing common challenges.

Alignment with Case Practices

This communication plan reflects the consensus-based approach used during the PM&C Program's design phase, including collaborative workshops and facilitated discussions. Integrating these practices into implementation supports continuity, reinforces stakeholder engagement, and ensures that the PM&C system is adopted in a manner consistent with the principles established during its development (Northeastern University, 2023).

Communication Strategies to Mitigate Conflict

Effective communication is essential for resolving stakeholder tensions and supporting successful adoption of the PM&C system. Because the identified conflicts stem from differences in authority, operational needs, resource constraints, and expectations for standardization, the communication strategies must directly address these sources of friction. The following strategies apply communication principles to the specific conflict patterns identified in the Heublein case (HelpGuide, 2023; Indeed, 2024).

Emphasizing Flexibility and Customization

Reinforcing that the PM&C system allows for tailored implementation helps address concerns about excessive standardization. The "menu" approach to project plan components is particularly effective for Groups with diverse project types and engineering capabilities. By clearly communicating which elements are required for major projects and which can be adapted for routine work, the program manager can reduce resistance and demonstrate respect for Group-specific operational needs.

Using the Consultant as a Neutral Facilitator

Continuing to use the consultant as a neutral facilitator provides a safe channel for raising concerns and helps prevent interpersonal conflict. The case describes the consultant as a "lightning rod" for criticism, which allows internal stakeholders to express concerns without damaging long-term working relationships. This approach is especially valuable when Groups and F&MP differ in their interpretations of project management practices or when sensitive discussions require impartial mediation.

Reinforcing Shared Organizational Goals

Linking PM&C practices to shared goals, such as improved capital utilization, reduced cost overruns, and stronger project performance, helps reduce tension between Corporate Management and Group leadership. When stakeholders understand how the PM&C system supports broader organizational objectives, they are more likely to view new requirements as purposeful rather than restrictive. This framing encourages alignment across hierarchical levels and reduces defensiveness.

Clarifying Accountability

Communicating clear roles and responsibilities through tools such as the accountability matrix reduces confusion and prevents process-based conflict. This strategy supports smoother coordination within Groups and across organizational levels by ensuring that stakeholders understand who is responsible for initiating, approving, or contributing to each component of the PM&C system. Clear accountability also supports F&MP's interest in system integrity and consistency.

Maintaining Two-Way Communication

Providing structured opportunities for feedback ensures that concerns are identified early and that stakeholders feel heard. Two-way communication supports collaborative problem solving and strengthens commitment to the PM&C system. This strategy is particularly effective for mitigating conflicts between F&MP and engineering departments, where differences in perspective may lead to tension.

Ensuring Consistent and Predictable Messaging

Clear and predictable communication across Corporate Management, F&MP, and Group leadership reduces uncertainty and prevents misunderstandings that can escalate into conflict. Consistency in messaging reinforces trust, supports smoother implementation, and ensures that stakeholders receive aligned information regardless of their position within the organization.

Conclusion

The Heublein PM&C Program brings together a wide range of stakeholders whose interests, priorities, and operational contexts differ significantly, creating a complex environment for organizational change. By examining these interests in detail and identifying the structural, interpersonal, and process-based conflicts that arise from them, the organization is better positioned to design communication approaches that support alignment and reduce resistance. The analysis of the case study from *Project Management: A Managerial Approach* (Meredith et al., 2021) demonstrates that many of the tensions within and between Groups, Corporate Management, F&MP, and project teams stem from legitimate differences in authority, resource constraints, operational needs, and expectations for standardization.

A communication approach that emphasizes clarity, consistency, and two-way engagement is essential for navigating these tensions. Reinforcing flexibility where appropriate, ensuring neutral facilitation during sensitive discussions, clarifying accountability, and connecting PM&C practices to shared organizational goals all contribute to reducing friction and strengthening stakeholder buy-in. These practices align with recommended conflict-resolution principles that highlight the importance of active listening, collaborative problem solving, and predictable communication channels (HelpGuide, 2023; Indeed, 2024). Since the PM&C system fundamentally changes how projects are planned, monitored, and reported, its success depends less on the technical design of the tools and far more on whether communication enables stakeholders to understand, accept, and consistently apply the new practices.

With sustained engagement, transparent communication, and a commitment to balancing standardization with operational autonomy, Heublein is well positioned to achieve the intended outcomes of the PM&C Program. These outcomes include improved project execution, stronger financial control, enhanced cross-group coordination, and more effective use of capital funds. Continued investment in communication, training, and stakeholder involvement will help the organization build long-term capability and realize the full benefits of a corporate-wide project management and control system.

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